

Before money moves: 10 checks that stop fake-invoice and wire fraud

Business email compromise in plain English: how it happens, and the habits and settings that stop it.

How it happens. A criminal sends an email that looks like it comes from a vendor, your boss, a title company or a client, or writes from a real mailbox they broke into. It asks you to pay an invoice to "new" bank details, change where payroll goes, or buy gift cards, usually in a hurry. The FBI's Internet Crime Complaint Center counts more than \$55 billion in exposed losses from these scams between October 2013 and December 2023.

Habits (they cost nothing)

- 1. Call before you change bank details.** Confirm every new or changed payment instruction by phone, using a number you already had. Never use the number in the email.
- 2. Treat urgency as a warning sign.** "Today", "keep this confidential", "I'm in a meeting, just do it" is the pattern. Slow down and check.
- 3. Two people approve large payments.** Pick a dollar amount above which a second person signs off, and write it down.
- 4. Read the real sender address, not just the name,** especially on a phone. Look for one changed letter or an extra word in the domain.
- 5. Never send passwords, codes or personal details by email,** even when the request seems to come from IT or your bank.

Settings (set once)

- 6. Multi-factor sign-in on every mailbox,** the owner's included, so a stolen password alone cannot open it.
- 7. A unique password for email and for banking.** A password manager makes this easy.
- 8. SPF, DKIM and DMARC on your own domain,** with DMARC set to quarantine or reject, so criminals cannot send email that looks like it comes from you. Free check in 10 seconds: supremeitexperts.com/check
- 9. Check mailbox forwarding and rules.** Criminals who get into a mailbox often add a hidden rule that forwards or hides replies. Ask whoever runs your email to look now and to alert on new ones.

If money already went out

- 10. Call your bank immediately and ask for a recall of the transfer,** then report it at ic3.gov, whatever the amount. Speed matters: the FBI's IC3 may be able to help banks freeze the funds.

Questions? Supreme IT Experts - (610) 500-9209 - supremeitexperts.com - Free 30-minute IT + AI Checkup: supremeitexperts.com/checkup

General information, not legal, banking or insurance advice.